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The AI-Ready VA Starter Guide

10 AI services you can sell to the clients you already have, with what to charge and how to pitch them

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Before you start

Your clients have heard that AI can save them hours every week. Most of them have tried it once or twice, got a so-so answer, and gone back to doing things the old way. They don't have time to learn it properly, and they don't know which of their jobs AI is actually good at.

You do know their jobs. You see their inbox, their calendar, their content calendar, their messy shared drive and the questions their customers ask every week. That puts you in the best position of anyone to make AI work inside their business.

I spent more than 25 years running operations, most recently as COO of a business coaching company where we grew revenue from about $5 million to $16 million with a team of more than 50 people. What business owners want from the people who support them hasn't changed: take work off my plate, and make it run without me. AI is now the fastest way to deliver both.

This guide shows you how to turn that into paid work. You'll learn:

- Why AI is a raise for good VAs, not a threat
- The three levels of an AI-ready VA, and how each one gets paid
- 10 AI services you can offer this month, with what the client gets and what to charge
- How to price AI work so you aren't punished for being fast
- A short pitch you can send to a current client today
- The client data rules to follow from day one
- A 7-day plan to land your first paid AI service

How to use this guide

- **Read Chapters 1 to 3 first.** They explain how AI work gets paid.
- **Pick one service from Chapter 4.** Choose the one that solves a problem you already see at a client. Don't try to offer all ten.
- **Use the pitch in Chapter 6 with one current client.** An existing client who trusts you is ten times easier than a stranger.
- **Fill in every [bracket]** in a template before you use it.

Chapter 1: AI is a raise, not a replacement

There's a lot of worry that AI will replace virtual assistants. Here's what I see instead: AI replaces *tasks*. It doesn't replace the person who knows which tasks matter, how the client likes things done, and when something looks wrong.

A business owner who hands their inbox to a chatbot with no one watching it gets embarrassing replies and missed deals. A business owner who has a VA set up AI to sort the inbox, draft replies and flag what's urgent gets their mornings back, and keeps a human in charge.

That second version is a better service than you can deliver by hand, and it's worth more. The VAs who will struggle are the ones who keep selling hours of manual work while their clients read about AI every day. The VAs who will do well are the ones who walk in and say: *"I can set this up for you, and I'll run it."*

What changes when you become AI-ready

Before	After
You sell hours	You sell outcomes and systems
Your income is capped by your calendar	A setup fee plus a monthly fee for running it
Clients see you as support	Clients see you as the person who makes their business run
Easy to replace with a cheaper VA	Hard to replace, because you built the system

Your move

Write down every recurring task you do for each client. Next to each one, mark it **R** if it's repetitive (same steps every time), **J** if it needs your judgment, or **B** for both. The R and B tasks are where AI services come from.

Chapter 2: The three levels of an AI-ready VA

You don't need to be technical to start, and you don't have to jump straight to the top. Most VAs move through three levels.

Level 1: AI-assisted VA

You use AI to do your own work faster: drafting emails, summarizing calls, writing first drafts of posts, cleaning up documents.

- **Who benefits:** you. You deliver faster and take on more.
- **How you get paid:** the same way as now, but you can fit more clients in, or move to package pricing instead of hourly (see Chapter 5).

Level 2: AI setup VA

You build an AI routine *for* the client: a set of instructions, a few templates and a schedule that does one job in their business. For example, a weekly report that drafts itself every Monday.

- **Who benefits:** the client, every week, whether you're online or not.
- **How you get paid:** a one-time setup fee.

Level 3: AI operator VA

You run a small team of AI agents for the client. You check their work, fix what breaks, add new ones as the business grows, and report back on the hours saved.

- **Who benefits:** the client gets a working AI system without learning any of it.
- **How you get paid:** a setup fee for each agent plus a monthly fee to run and improve them.

Level 3 is where the money is. One client paying $400 a month to keep five agents running is worth more than 15 hours of manual admin, and it takes you far less time once it's built.

Your move

Decide which level you're at today. If you're not using AI daily for your own work yet, spend one week at Level 1 before you sell anything. You need to trust the tools before you can sell them.

Chapter 3: The tools you need (and the ones you don't)

You need far fewer tools than the internet suggests.

The core: one AI assistant

Pick one of the big general assistants and learn it well: **Claude** or **ChatGPT** are the two I recommend. Both can work from a saved set of instructions, read files you upload, connect to common business apps, and run jobs on a schedule on their paid plans. Features and plan names change often, so check the current plan pages before you promise a client anything.

The skills carry over. If you learn to write good instructions and break a job into steps in one assistant, you can do it in the other.

The client's own apps

Most AI services plug into tools your client already pays for: Google Workspace or Microsoft 365, their email, calendar, CRM, social scheduler, help desk or bookkeeping software. You aren't adding software. You're making their existing software do more.

What you don't need

- A dozen niche AI apps. Each one is another login, another bill and another place for client data to leak.
- Coding skills. Everything in this guide is built from plain-English instructions.
- Expensive automation platforms on day one. Add them later, when a client has a job that truly needs one.

Your move

If you don't have a paid plan on Claude or ChatGPT, get one. It's a business expense, and you'll earn it back on your first setup fee.

Chapter 4: 10 AI services you can sell this month

Each service below includes what it is, what the client gets, how long setup usually takes, and a starting price range. The prices are starting points for a VA working with small businesses in the US. Adjust them to your market and your experience, and see Chapter 5 for how to set your own.

Service 1: Inbox triage and draft replies

What it is: AI sorts the client's inbox every morning into urgent, needs a reply, FYI and junk, and drafts replies to the routine messages for you or the client to approve.

What the client gets: a clean inbox and a short morning list of what actually needs them.

Setup: 2 to 4 hours. **Starting price:** $300 to $600 setup, $150 to $300 a month to run.

Service 2: Meeting notes and follow-up

What it is: after every client or sales call, AI turns the recording or transcript into a summary, a list of action items with owners, and a draft follow-up email.

What the client gets: no more "what did we agree?" and no forgotten follow-ups.

Setup: 1 to 3 hours. **Starting price:** $250 to $500 setup, $100 to $250 a month.

Service 3: Content repurposing

What it is: one piece of content, such as a podcast, video, webinar or long post, becomes a week of social posts, an email and a short blog draft, all in the client's voice.

What the client gets: a steady content calendar without writing from scratch.

Setup: 3 to 5 hours, mostly teaching the AI the client's voice. **Starting price:** $400 to $800 setup, $300 to $600 a month.

Service 4: Customer support first drafts

What it is: AI drafts answers to common customer questions from the client's own FAQ, policies and past replies. A human checks each one before it goes out.

What the client gets: faster replies, consistent answers and a support inbox that doesn't pile up.

Setup: 4 to 6 hours. **Starting price:** $500 to $900 setup, $200 to $400 a month.

Service 5: Bookkeeping prep

What it is: AI reads receipts and statements, suggests a category for each expense, and flags anything odd for the client or their bookkeeper. It prepares the work; a person still approves it.

What the client gets: a tidy month-end and a smaller bill from their accountant.

Setup: 2 to 4 hours. **Starting price:** $300 to $600 setup, $150 to $300 a month.

Service 6: Weekly business report

What it is: every Monday, AI pulls the numbers the client cares about (sales, leads, website visits, open invoices) into a one-page summary with three things to look at this week.

What the client gets: a clear picture of the business in five minutes.

Setup: 3 to 5 hours. **Starting price:** $400 to $700 setup, $150 to $300 a month.

Service 7: Lead research and CRM cleanup

What it is: AI researches new leads before a call, fills in missing details in the CRM, and flags duplicate or stale contacts.

What the client gets: walking into every sales call prepared, and a CRM they can trust.

Setup: 2 to 4 hours. **Starting price:** $300 to $600 setup, $150 to $350 a month.

Service 8: Standard operating procedures

What it is: the client records themselves doing a task, or talks it through, and AI turns it into a clean, step-by-step procedure. You build a library of them.

What the client gets: the business knowledge out of their head and into documents anyone can follow, including you.

Setup: 1 to 2 hours per procedure. **Starting price:** $75 to $200 per procedure, or a package of 10.

Service 9: Newsletter drafting

What it is: AI drafts the weekly or monthly newsletter from the client's notes, recent posts and news in their industry. You edit, format and schedule it.

What the client gets: a newsletter that actually goes out on time.

Setup: 2 to 3 hours. **Starting price:** $300 to $500 setup, $200 to $500 a month.

Service 10: New client onboarding pack

What it is: when the client signs a new customer, AI drafts the welcome email, the kickoff agenda, the intake questions and the first-week checklist, all personalized from the signed proposal.

What the client gets: a polished first impression every time, without rebuilding it from scratch.

Setup: 3 to 5 hours. **Starting price:** $400 to $800 setup, $100 to $250 a month.

> **Which one should you start with?**
>
> Start with the service that fixes a problem your client has complained about in the last month. If they've said "I'm drowning in email," start with Service 1. If they've said "I never post anymore," start with Service 3. A service that answers a complaint sells itself.

Your move

Choose one service and one client. Write one sentence on the problem it fixes for them, in their words.

Chapter 5: How to price AI work

The fastest way to lose money on AI is to keep billing by the hour. If a job that used to take you five hours now takes one, hourly billing cuts your pay by 80% for doing better work.

Price AI work in two parts.

Part 1: The setup fee

This pays for building the system: learning the job, writing the instructions, testing it on real examples and training the client. A simple way to set it:

> **Setup fee**
>
> (Hours to build and test) × (your hourly rate) × 1.5

The 1.5 covers the learning you've done to be able to build it at all, and the fact that the client gets something that keeps working after you've left.

Part 2: The monthly fee

This pays for running it: checking the output, fixing what breaks, updating the instructions when the business changes and reporting the results. Anchor it to the value, not your time:

> **Monthly fee check**
>
> Hours saved per month × the client's hourly value ÷ 4

If the client values their time at $100 an hour and the service saves them 10 hours a month, that's $1,000 of value. A fee of about $250 a month is an easy yes for them, even if it takes you only an hour or two to run.

Package it

Clients find a package easier to say yes to than a list of fees. For example:

Package	What's in it	Starting price
AI Starter	1 service set up and run	$300 setup + $150/month
AI Office	3 services set up and run, monthly report	$900 setup + $400/month
AI Operator	5+ services, monthly review call, new service each quarter	$1,500 setup + $750/month

Your move

Work out the setup fee and monthly fee for the service you picked in Chapter 4. Write them down before you talk to the client, so you don't discount on the spot.

Chapter 6: The pitch

Your first AI client should be someone you already work with. They trust you, you know their business and you can point to a specific problem.

The message

> **Pitch email to a current client**
>
> Hi [Name],
>
> I've noticed [specific problem, in their words, such as "Monday mornings go to clearing the inbox"]. I've been setting up AI tools that handle exactly this kind of work, and I think I could set one up for you.
>
> Here's what it would do: [one or two sentences on the service from Chapter 4].
>
> I'd expect it to save you around [X] hours a month. Setup is [setup fee] and then [monthly fee] a month for me to run it, check its work and keep it improving.
>
> Want me to show you a quick example using [a real, non-sensitive example from their business] before you decide?
>
> [Your name]

Why it works

- **It starts with their problem**, not with AI. Clients buy relief, not technology.
- **It offers a demo.** Showing beats explaining. Build a rough version on a safe example before the call.
- **It names the price.** You've done the thinking, so you look like a professional, not someone asking for permission.

If they say "can't I just do this myself?"

Yes, they can, the same way they could do their own admin. Say so, then explain what they're really buying: "You could. Most of my clients would rather spend those hours on the business. I'll set it up, check it every week, and fix it when something changes, so you never have to think about it."

Your move

Send the pitch to one client this week. Change every [bracket] first.

Chapter 7: Client data rules

Nothing ends a client relationship faster than a data mistake. Follow these rules from your very first AI job.

1. **Get written permission** before you use AI on any client data. One email confirming what you'll use and where is enough.
2. **Use the client's account, not your personal one,** for anything that touches their customers, finances or staff. If they don't have a business plan with an AI provider, recommend one that doesn't use their data for training, and confirm the current settings in the provider's own documentation.
3. **Never paste sensitive data into a free tool.** That means passwords, card numbers, bank details, health information, social security numbers and anything covered by a privacy agreement.
4. **Connect apps with the least access the job needs.** If a service only needs to read a calendar, don't give it permission to send email.
5. **Keep a human in the loop** for anything that goes to a customer or moves money. AI drafts; a person approves.
6. **Write it down.** Keep a one-page list for each client of which AI tools you use, what they can access and who approves the output.

> **Tip**
>
> Clients notice when you bring this up first. Talking about data safety before they ask is one of the strongest trust signals you can send, and it sets you apart from VAs who just "use ChatGPT."

Chapter 8: Your 7-day plan

Here's how to go from reading this guide to your first paid AI service in a week.

Day	What to do	Time
1	List every recurring task for each client and mark R, J or B (Chapter 1)	30 minutes
2	Pick one service and one client. Write the problem in their words (Chapter 4)	20 minutes
3	Build a rough version of the service on a safe example	1 to 2 hours
4	Set your setup fee and monthly fee (Chapter 5)	20 minutes
5	Send the pitch (Chapter 6)	15 minutes
6	Show the demo, answer questions, confirm data permissions in writing (Chapter 7)	30 minutes
7	Start the build, and put a check-in on your calendar for two weeks out	1 hour

After your first service is running, ask the client what's still eating their week. That answer is your second service.

What's next

You now have the business model. The next step is building the services well.

20 AI Agents That Pay for Themselves gives you 20 step-by-step agent builds you can set up for clients in Claude or ChatGPT: the exact instructions to paste, the schedule to set, and the math on what each one saves. It's $49 at **virtualexpert.net/agents**.

The AI-Ready VA Course takes you from your first AI service to running AI for several clients, with 8 modules, templates, a toolkit and a certification you can show clients. See it at **virtualexpert.net/va-course**.

Questions? Reply to any of my emails. I read them all.

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